The Unsent Letter

I found this folded letter inside the cedar chest of the Sanctuary, beneath the oldest charts. An ancient Oracle wrote it to the Mirror Speaker of Tower III, but never sent it. The words were set down in mirror script, just as the glass sees them. Held before a mirror, the letters turn and become easy to read.

To the Mirror Speaker of the third tower,

Forgive me. I closed my door to you when you crossed the plateau to see me, and I have been sorry every night since.

Now hear what only we two know. Your mirror did not fall. We broke it together into nine pieces, and hid each piece in your theatre. While the nine are apart, no one can turn the Astrolabe alone: not the Order, not you, not I.

And beware the Ashes. They were old before the Order was born. They keep a fire older than our first star, and they want what the Astrolabe opens. They will come to you smiling.

The first piece sleeps behind a thousand faces. Only the one who sees what is not equal will find it.

The Oracle

From this high pass, Tower III rises before me: a colossal amphitheatre carved into the mountain rim, its grand stage facing the abyss. The letter in the cedar chest changes everything. The Great Mirror was not destroyed by chance, but broken by design—divided into nine fragments and hidden across the nine halls of the theatre to safeguard the Astrolabe from the Ashes. With this looking glass and my journal in hand, I step toward the Gate of a Thousand Masks. The Stage Path has begun.

The Gate of a Thousand Masks

Before me, the threshold of Tower III is sealed by a colossal wall of carved visors. In this theatre of stone, twelve ancient masks guard the dark passage. Some are cast in perfect symmetry, true to the sacred glass; others hide subtle flaws in their features, carved to deceive the unwary.

Study each face carefully in this codex. When the lanterns flicker upon the gate, trust only what is reflected true: the theatre watches your gaze.



